MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) Regular EXAMINATION March 2026

Fourth SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Elective (DSE) - MG4DSEPSYA00 - DEVELOPMENTAL AND SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGY IN CINEMA- SCHEME

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Students are free to select any movie as an example based on their interpretation, provided that it accurately reflects the underlying psychological concept.

Part A

Short Answer Questions. Answer any 5 questions Each question carries 4 marks

1. List the key features of existential anxiety. What situations or moments trigger it? Illustrate with a movie example

Existential anxiety refers to the deep psychological tension individuals experience while searching for meaning in life. Unlike everyday stress or fear, existential anxiety is rooted in fundamental human concerns such as **death, freedom, isolation, and meaninglessness**.

It comes from questions like:

● *Who am I really? -What is the meaning of my life? -Am I alone in this world? -What happens if everything I believe in collapses?*

This anxiety often appears during **crises**, **loss**, or moments when a person feels **directionless** or **disconnected from life**.

Key Features of Existential Anxiety : Feeling of **emptiness** - Loss of **meaning or purpose** -Fear of **loneliness or isolation** -Confusion about **identity** - Feeling that life is **out of control**

Malayalam Movie Example: *Uyare* (2019) : Although *Uyare* is often discussed as a survival or feminist film, it also strongly represents **existential anxiety**, especially through the **body and identity**. After the acid attack, Pallavi's identity collapses:

● She is no longer recognized by her face

● Her body, which once gave her confidence, becomes a source of fear and rejection This creates **existential anxiety**:

"Who am I if I am no longer the person I used to be?"

2. Explain Erikson's stage of Identity vs Role Confusion. Describe how this conflict is depicted through a suitable cinematic representation

   Stage 5: Identity vs. Role Confusion
   Age Group: 12–18 years (Adolescence)

Core Psychological Question: “Who am I?”
At this stage, the adolescent: Explores different roles-Experiments with values, beliefs, and goals- Faces peer pressure and societal expectations-Tries to form a stable identity

If this stage is:
Successfully resolved → Identity Achievement (Fidelity)- Unsuccessfully resolved → Role Confusion

Kumbalangi Nights – Bobby

● Bobby struggles with: Masculinity- Emotional Expression-Family roles

● He: Cannot express love properly-Suffers emotional confusion-Has low self-worth

Resolution:

He slowly learns emotional maturity → Achieves Identity

This shows how identity develops through emotional learning and relationships.

3. Explain how strong group norms suppress individual dissent. Briefly discuss this with reference to a cinematic context

Social norms are shared rules or expectations about how group members should think, feel,

and behave.

Baron & Byrne explain that norms: Maintain order and predictability-Promote group cohesion-Influence conformity-Are enforced through approval or disapproval

People follow norms mainly to: Gain acceptance-Avoid rejection

Malayalam Movie Example: Premam

● College norms dictate dressing style, romance, masculinity, and behaviour

● Characters conform to peer culture to fit in

Psychological insight:

The film shows how norms silently guide behaviour without explicit force.

4. Describe Good Boy-Girl stage and the role of relationships. Any movie example of approval-seeking acts.
Morality here is defined by intentions and relationships.
An action is right if it pleases others, maintains harmony, or confirms one’s image as a “good”person.
Empathy develops, but morality is still dependent on social validation.

Malayalam Cinema Illustration: **Thoovanathumbikal**
Jayakrishnan’s moral decisions are shaped by:

- Emotional bonds

- Desire to be seen as caring and honorable
- Sensitivity to others' feelings

His morality is deeply relational, reflecting Stage 3 reasoning.
Charlie: Charlie portrays morality driven by kindness, empathy, and emotional connection—doing good to maintain warmth and social harmony.

5. Explain how cinema gives voice to marginalized groups. Briefly discuss its importance in social representation.

The concepts of in-groups and out-groups originate from social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner). An in-group refers to a social group with which an individual identifies and feels a sense of belonging ("us"), while an out-group refers to groups perceived as different or outside one's identity ("them").

This classification plays a crucial role in shaping attitudes, emotional attachment, loyalty, cooperation, and sometimes hostility toward others. Humans naturally categorize people to simplify social interaction, but this often leads to bias, stereotyping, and discrimination.

Cinematic Portrayal

Cinema frequently uses "us versus them" narratives to depict conflict between:

● Caste groups

● Political ideologies

● Economic classes

● Ethnic or religious identities

For example, Malayalam films portraying urban marginalization often highlight dominant groups versus marginalized communities. These portrayals show how in-group favouritism leads to solidarity within groups but exclusion of others.

Psychological Impact

Such group divisions: Strengthen identity and belongingness- Increase prejudice and intergroup conflict-Influence decision-making and moral judgment-Sometimes promote empathy when boundaries are challenged

Cinema thus helps viewers understand how group identities shape real-life social interactions.

6. Describe Bowlby's core idea of attachment as a survival mechanism for infants forming bonds with caregivers.

John Bowlby's Attachment Theory explains that the emotional bond formed between an infant and primary caregiver becomes the foundation for later relationships. Through early interactions, the child develops internal working models about:

Self → Am I worthy of love?
Others → Are people reliable and supportive?
Bowlby argued that infants are **born with attachment behaviors** such as:

- Crying
- Clinging
- Smiling
- Following

These behaviors are not random — they are **evolutionary survival strategies**. They help keep the caregiver close, which:

- Protects the infant from danger
- Ensures feeding and care
- Increases chances of survival

Why Attachment Matters

According to Bowlby:

- Infants form a **strong emotional bond** with a primary caregiver (usually the mother or main caregiver).
- This bond provides a **"secure base"**, allowing the child to explore the world safely.
- When the caregiver is absent, infants show **separation anxiety**, which is also adaptive (it motivates reunion).

7. Explain the concept of death–rebirth symbolism in the Hero's Journey.

In the hero's journey, death and rebirth symbolize a profound psychological transformation where the protagonist sheds their old identity ("dies") to emerge as a wiser, more resilient, and empowered individual ("reborn"). This pivotal, often symbolic event typically occurs during the innermost cave or resurrection stages.

Part B
Short Essay Questions Answer any 5 questions Each question carries 7 marks

8. Evaluate meaning-focused and social coping strategies in managing grief, including their role in fostering resilience, with examples from psychological literature or films.
Coping refers to the cognitive and behavioral efforts individuals use to manage stress, loss, or emotionally challenging situations.
According to Lazarus & Folkman, coping is not about eliminating stress but managing internal and external demands.
Meaning-Focused Coping: Finding purpose, meaning, or growth in suffering.
Includes:
● Acceptance

● Spirituality
● Altruism
● Post-traumatic growth

Malayalam example: Niranjana (Manju Warrier) – How Old Are You
Transforms mid-life crisis into self-growth and empowerment.
Excellent illustration of positive reappraisal and resilience.

Social Coping: Managing stress through interpersonal relationships.
Includes:
● Family support
● Friendship
● Community belonging
Malayalam example: Majeed – Sudani from Nigeria
Community support helps characters cope with loss, identity, and emotional pain.

9. Discuss normative social influence and informational social influence. Explain how both forms of influence are depicted through characters in films.
Social influence refers to the way individuals change their behavior, attitudes, or beliefs due to the presence or pressure of others. Two major types are **normative social influence** and **informational social influence**.
1. Normative Social Influence
Normative social influence occurs when a person conforms to a group in order to be liked, accepted, or to avoid rejection. The individual may not genuinely agree with the group but follows it to maintain social harmony.
Key Features:

- Desire for approval or acceptance
- Fear of rejection or social isolation
- Public compliance without private acceptance

In *Premam*, the character **George** is influenced by his peer group during his college life. He adopts certain behaviours, attitudes, and lifestyle patterns similar to his friends to fit in with the group. His actions are not always based on personal belief but on the need for acceptance and belonging. This reflects **normative social influence**, where conformity is driven by social approval.

2. Informational Social Influence
Informational social influence occurs when a person conforms because they believe others have more accurate knowledge, especially in uncertain or ambiguous situations. Here, the individual genuinely accepts the group's viewpoint as correct.
Key Features:

- Desire to be correct
- Occurs in uncertain situations
- Leads to internalization (true belief change)

In *Drishyam*, the family members rely completely on **Georgekutty's** knowledge and instructions during a crisis. Since they are confused and scared, they believe he knows what is right and follow his guidance. This shows **informational social influence**, where people accept others' opinions as correct in uncertain situations.

10. Explain how cinema represents internal psychological transformation during midlife. Discuss the shift from external success to internal meaning, using suitable visual narratives.

    Midlife corresponds to Erikson's Generativity vs Stagnation stage. Erikson's seventh stage is Generativity vs. Stagnation, occurring in middle adulthood (around 40-65 years), where adults focus on contributing to future generations through parenting, mentoring, or community work, aiming to create something lasting, while failure to do so leads to feelings of being unproductive or disconnecte (stagnation). Successfully navigating this stage fosters a sense of purpose and achievement, with the core virtue being Care.

    A feeling of being stuck, lacking purpose, or being overly focused on personal needs, leading to disengagement.

    Virtue:

    Care, the ability to guide younger generations and contribute to the world.

    Examples of Generativity in films

    a) Raising children to become responsible adults.b) Mentoring younger colleagues at work.c) Volunteering in the community or leading local initiatives. d) Engaging in creative projects that benefit future generations.

11. Analyze generativity vs. stagnation in a midlife anti-hero mentoring youths; show legacy-building amid decline.

    Erikson's seventh stage is Generativity vs. Stagnation, occurring in middle adulthood (around 40-65 years), where adults focus on contributing to future generations through parenting, mentoring, or community work, aiming to create something lasting, while failure to do so leads to feelings of being unproductive or disconnected (stagnation). Successfully navigating this stage fosters a sense of purpose and achievement, with the core virtue being Care.

    Examples of Generativity in films

    a) Raising children to become responsible adults.b) Mentoring younger colleagues at work.c) Volunteering in the community or leading local initiatives. d) Engaging in creative projects that benefit future generations.

    Generativity: A desire to make a positive impact and leave a legacy, often through raising children, mentoring, volunteering, or contributing to society.
    Stagnation: A feeling of being stuck, lacking purpose, or being overly focused on personal needs, leading to disengagement.
    Core Conflicts:
    - "Is this all there is?"
    - Fear of aging
    - Unfulfilled dreams
    - Identity stagnation

    Cinematic Representation:
    - Career dissatisfaction
    - Marital breakdown
    - Sudden life changes
    - Rediscovery of purpose

Midlife films often echo the second Hero's Journey, where transformation is internal rather than external.

12. Discuss the life-story construct of agency. Explain how high or low agency in personal narratives is related to self-confidence, resilience, and mental health.

Agency: Agency refers to the degree to which the protagonist:
- Acts independently
- Exercises control over life events
- Influences others or the environment

Highly agentic stories emphasize:
- Achievement
- Self-mastery
- Empowerment
- Control over one's fate

Key Indicators
- "I decided..."
- "I took charge..."
- "I accomplished..."

Example (High Agency) : "I challenge myself to the limit academically, physically, and on my job. Since that time of my divorce, I have accomplished virtually any goal I set for myself."

Psychological Significance
High agency is associated with:
- Self-confidence
- Psychological resilience
- Better mental health

13. Define stereotype threat. Explain its psychological mechanisms and discuss how cinematic narratives depict its effect on performance and self-concept.

Stereotype threat refers to the psychological pressure experienced by individuals when they fear confirming a negative stereotype about their social group. This concept was introduced by Steele and explains how awareness of stereotypes can impair performance.

<u>Psychological Mechanisms</u>
Stereotype threat operates through:
1. Performance Anxiety – Fear of confirming stereotypes leads to stress.
2. Cognitive Load – Worry consumes mental resources.
3. Self-Doubt – Reduced confidence affects motivation.
4. Identity Conflict – Individuals question their social identity.

<u>Cinematic Representation</u>
Cinema portrays stereotype threat through characters facing social stigma:
- Acid attack survivors facing beauty stereotypes.
- Women professionals confronting gender bias.
- Marginalized caste or ethnic individuals proving competence.

Such narratives show:
- Emotional struggle
- Internal conflict

● Efforts to overcome societal expectations
These portrayals illustrate how stereotypes affect both performance and self-concept.

Effects on Individuals
● Lower academic or professional performance
● Reduced self-esteem
● Social withdrawal
● Long-term psychological distress

14. Describe new chances after loss in movies; show a sad hero starting a fresh happy path.
Movies often portray how individuals experience deep loss but eventually find **new meaning, hope, and happiness** in life. This theme highlights human resilience—the ability to rebuild life even after emotional pain or failure.

(student can answer this question in **two flexible ways**:
1. Using **movies as examples**, or
2. Using **Campbell's Theory of the Hero's Journey (Monomyth)** directly.)

Basic Stages of the Hero's Journey
- **Ordinary World** – Hero's normal life
- **Call to Adventure** – A challenge or problem appears
- **Refusal of the Call** – Hero hesitates or avoids
- **Meeting the Mentor** – Guidance/support is given
- **Crossing the Threshold** – Hero enters a new world
- **Trials & Challenges** – Faces obstacles, enemies
- **Crisis / Ordeal** – Biggest challenge (turning point)
- **Reward** – Gains something (strength, knowledge, success)
- **Return** – Comes back transformed

Part C

Essay Questions
Answer any 1 question Each question carries 15 marks

15. Differentiate between obedience, conformity, and compliance. Examine how films portray each of these social influence processes in different narrative contexts.

Conformity refers to a change in an individual's behaviour, attitudes, or beliefs in order to match the norms, standards, or expectations of a group due to real or imagined social pressure. (Solomon asch experiment)
1. Normative Conformity: Normative conformity occurs when individuals conform to group norms to gain social approval or to avoid rejection. The individual may privately disagree but publicly comply.
2. Informational Conformity: Informational conformity occurs when individuals conform because they believe the group's judgment is correct, especially in ambiguous or uncertain situations.

The Great Indian Kitchen (2021)
This film is a strong illustration of normative conformity. The female protagonist conforms to traditional gender roles and household norms to gain acceptance within her marital family. Despite emotional distress, she continues to conform due to social pressure, highlighting how conformity can lead to psychological strain.

Obedience is a form of social influence in which an individual follows direct orders or commands given by an authority figure. The authority may be formal (police, government, teachers) or informal (parents, elders, leaders). (Stanley Milgram experiment)
Obedience usually involves:
● Hierarchical relationship
● Presence of authority

● Fear of punishment
● Acceptance of authority's legitimacy
Nayattu (2021)
Nayattu is a strong illustration of obedience to political and institutional authority. Police officers follow unethical orders due to hierarchical pressure and fear of consequences. The film clearly reflects Milgram's agentic state, where individuals obey authority while suppressing moral judgment.

16. Define cultural narratives and discuss their psychological functions. Examine how films reflect, reinforce, and challenge cultural narratives related to family, gender roles, class, or tradition, using any suitable movie example.

    Cultural narratives are shared stories shaped by society, tradition, religion, gender roles, and historical context. Movies reflect these through:
    ● Family systems and social expectations
    ● Moral values and belief systems
    ● Gender roles and power dynamics
    ● Collective identity (community, nation, caste, class)

    Psychologically, cultural narratives:
    ● Shape beliefs, norms, and behaviour
    ● Influence identity formation
    ● Create internal conflict when personal desires clash with tradition
    Example:
    The Great Indian Kitchen highlights cultural narratives around patriarchy and gender roles, showing how deeply social conditioning affects mental health.

    Functions of Cultural Narratives
    ● Defining Identity and Belonging: These narratives answer foundational questions like "Who are we?" and "What truly matters?". They create a "map" for navigating life, reinforcing social cohesion and shared identity.
    ● Social Control and Normalization: Cultural narratives establish what is considered "normal" behavior versus "deviant". By rewarding those who align with these norms with acceptance, they serve as a subtle means of social regulation.
    ● Historical and Value Transmission: They act as a "repository of collective wisdom," passing down beliefs, ethics, and historical interpretations across

generations.

Types of Cultural Narratives in Film

● Dominant Narratives: These are widespread stories supported by powerful institutions like governments and major media outlets. Examples include:
○ The American Dream: The narrative of prosperity achieved through individual hard work and self-reliance.
○ Traditional Gender Archetypes: Portrayals that reduce characters to one-dimensional traits—such as women as "nurturing" and men as "aggressive"—to align with societal expectations.

● Counter-Narratives: Films that challenge dominant stories to offer new perspectives, especially for marginalized groups.
○ 13th (2016): A documentary that uses historical and legal narratives to challenge dominant views on mass incarceration and systemic racism in the U.S..
○ Black Panther (2018): Redefines cultural representation by popularizing Afrofuturism and creating new imaginaries of empowerment outside of Western-centric narratives.

● Hybrid and Transnational Narratives: Emerging in a globalized era, these films blend diverse cultural elements, often challenging rigid national identities.
○ The Lunchbox (2013): Successfully bridges local Indian storytelling with global cinematic trends by focusing on intimate, everyday interactions rather than grand spectacles.